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THE FOURTH DIMENSION

Diamond Harbour FC is **poised** to join the legacy trio of Indian football's top tier.

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Barely three years into its existence, Diamond Harbour FC seems to have achieved a lot. In a city that is generally preoccupied with the legacy of its big three clubs — Mohun Bagan, East Bengal and Mohammedan Sporting — Diamond Harbour FC is fast emerging as the fourth alternative in Kolkata's rich footballing heritage. Recording its birth on the Bengali New Year's Day on April 15, 2022, the club made a quick transition to the top division of the Calcutta Football League before turning its aspirations to achieving a national footprint.

That happened midway through April this year when it clinched the I-League 2 crown to secure a berth in next year's I-League, a milestone that very few clubs have been able to achieve in such a short span of time. The club is already eyeing a spot in the country's top league, the Indian Super League, which now remains just a step away. A title in the I-League will propel it to the constellation of the elites of Indian football (if the AIFF continues to follow the AFC roadmap).

That is currently the objective towards which the club is working. "Within a couple of years, we hope to qualify for the Premier A or B (of the Calcutta Football League).

We are confident of reaching greater heights within four-five years. If needed, we will also make a foray into ISL," is the message of its chief patron Abhishek Banerjee that greets the visitor venturing into the club's website. Those words were spoken during the club's inauguration by Mr Banerjee, who is the national general secretary of Trinamool Congress and the 'inspiration' behind the club's foundation.

"The Diamond Harbour MP Cup football tournament was started in 2017 by our Chief Patron, who is very fond of the game. It became an overnight success, and brought all the people in Diamond Harbour together as one in support of the sport. After seeing this love and passion for football, Mr Banerjee had this vision of forming a football club for everyone of this region. Due to the pandemic this plan was delayed by a few years, but in 2022, once